Sofia's Aerial Mission

A cartwheel with NO hands. The drills, how to do them, and a plan to tick off from Oct 12 to Dec 31, 2026.

What is an aerial, really?

It's your cartwheel, but your legs go so fast and your chest stays so tall that your hands never need the floor. That's it. Nobody "jumps" an aerial. You **kick** it and you **push** it.

1. **The hurdle.** The step in. It's like winding up a spring.
2. **The push and the kick.** Front leg pushes the floor away HARD. Back leg kicks up FAST. Both at the same time.
3. **Chest up.** If your chest dives down, your hands will want to catch you. Keep your chest tall and look forward, not at the floor.

Almost every aerial that doesn't work is #3: chest dropped. Same thing as the "don't drop your head before the cartwheel" note in your solo. Fix one, you fix both.

The rules (not optional)

- **The real aerial is learned in Monday Acro** with your teacher spotting. That's where the first tries happen.
- **Mom and Dad don't spot aerials.** Spotting is a coach skill. They film, they cheer, they hold the mat steady.
- **Mat under you** for every drill at home. Every single one.
- **Warm up first.** About 5 minutes: jumping jacks, arm circles, leg swings, wrist circles.
- **Stop before tired.** Tired tricks teach your body the wrong way.
- **Not in the solo** until you've landed 20 in a row in class. A clean cartwheel beats a wobbly aerial every time.

How long does it take?

Most dancers with a good cartwheel take **4 to 10 months** from starting these drills to a real aerial. Some faster, some slower. The kids who get there are the ones who do the boring drills every week, not the ones who throw a hundred wild tries.

So the goal for December 31 is clean drills, not a finished aerial.

How to use this plan

- **Monday** is Acro class. Each week has one thing to do or ask there.
- **Thursday and Friday**: about 10 minutes of drills at home, on the mat.
- **Tick a box** only when that drill was done clean. Messy ones don't count, and that's fine.
- **Chest up**: tick it if the chest stayed up the whole session (on the video, or a grown-up watched).
- **Gates.** Each phase ends with a gate. Start the next phase only when the gate before it is ticked. Not yet? Keep doing the same list. **The dates are a guide, not a deadline.**
- **Shaded "later" boxes** are drills that come later. Start them only after the gate before them.
- The **cartwheel skills** on page 2 get ticked whenever they're clean, in class or at home.
- **The Acro teacher wins.** If she sets a different order or different drills, follow hers and cross ours out.
- Pages 3–4 explain every drill: how, what right looks like, what to watch for.

Say it before every drill

Push. Kick. Chest up. Eyes forward.

Earn it

Everything an aerial needs, one tick at a time.

The checklist · Practice → Aerial mission in the app

Tick each one when it's clean, in any order. The cartwheel skills, the strong ones and the drills are what make Sofia ready for spotted tries in class. The teacher decides when.

Cartwheel skills

- ☐ Cartwheel: straight arms and legs, fast, lands facing the start — date _____
- ☐ One-hand cartwheel on the FAR hand, 10 clean in a row — date _____
- ☐ One-hand cartwheel on the NEAR hand, 10 clean in a row — date _____
- ☐ Dive cartwheel (small hop before the hands) on the mat — date _____
- ☐ Round-off landing feet together, chest up — date _____

Strong enough

- ☐ 10 single-leg squats per leg — date _____
- ☐ 30-second hollow hold — date _____
- ☐ 20 jump lunges without stopping — date _____
- ☐ Standing long jump past my own height — date _____

Drills (mat only)

- ☐ Hurdle drill: step-hurdle-lunge, arms swing up, chest tall ×10 — date _____
- ☐ Front-leg drive: lunge → tall jump, back leg kicks up ×10 — date _____
- ☐ Fingertip cartwheels: near hand barely brushes the floor ×5 — date _____
- ☐ Cartwheel down a wedge: two hands → one hand → a brush — date _____

In class only

- ☐ Acro teacher has seen the drills and set the order — date _____
- ☐ First spotted aerial attempts (coach spotting, never a parent) — date _____
- ☐ Unspotted aerial on the mat — date _____
- ☐ 20 in a row on the floor → allowed in a dance — date _____

Near hand, far hand

In these sheets, the **near hand** is the first hand to reach the floor, the one closest to where you started. The **far hand** is the second one. Teachers don't all use the words the same way, so check with the Acro teacher.

Which side?

Do every drill on the side Sofia cartwheels. The **front leg** is the bent leg in her cartwheel lunge. The **back leg** is the one that kicks.

In class only: what each step means

Acro teacher has seen the drills and set the order: Film each drill from the side at normal speed and show the Acro teacher on Monday. Ask: which drills at home and which only in class? What order do you teach the aerial in? What is Sofia ready for right now? The teacher's answers beat this sheet.

First spotted aerial attempts (coach spotting, never a parent): Only in class, only with the coach spotting. At home, grown-ups film, cheer and hold the mat steady. They never spot aerials: spotting is a coach skill.

Unspotted aerial on the mat: When the teacher says Sofia is ready: an aerial on the mat with no spot, in class.

20 in a row on the floor → allowed in a dance: 20 clean aerials in a row on the floor in class. Then it can go into a dance. Until then, a clean cartwheel stays in the solo: it beats a wobbly aerial every time.

How to do the drills

What to do, what right looks like, what to watch for.

The 6 drills, step by step

About 10 minutes, on the mat, after the warm-up. Film from the side at normal speed and pause at the top: is the chest up and are the eyes forward?

1 · Hurdle drill · ×10

This is the wind-up. Stand tall, arms up. It works like a skip: step onto the back foot and hop on it while the front knee lifts, land, then reach the front leg forward into a lunge. The arms swing up by the ears as you land. Hold the lunge 2 seconds.

✓ **Right:** A small, low, forward hop (not a high jump). In the lunge: front knee bent over the toes, back leg straight, shoulders over the hips, arms straight by the ears, eyes forward.

⚠ **Watch for:** The chest tipping forward in the lunge, looking at the floor, arms reaching forward instead of up, or the front knee falling inward.

2 · Front-leg drive · ×10 · the engine

The engine, and the most important drill on the page. From the hurdle lunge, push the floor away HARD with the front leg and jump straight up. The back leg kicks up behind you, fast, straight and pointed. Land softly on the push leg with a bent knee. Reset between each one.

✓ **Right:** Real air, a fast kick (not a slow lift), and the chest stays up the whole time.

⚠ **Watch for:** The chest dropping to get the leg higher (that's the #1 reason aerials don't work), a bent back leg, a tiny push, or a stiff landing.

3 · One-hand cartwheels · far hand ×5, near hand ×5

A normal cartwheel, but only the FAR hand goes down: the second hand, the one farther along the line. The other arm stays up by the ear. Kick the legs over fast so the one hand only has to help. Near hand: the same, but only the first hand goes down.

✓ **Right:** 10 in a row with straight legs, landing in a lunge, and the free hand never reaching for the floor.

⚠ **Watch for:** The free hand sneaking down, the arm bending, or the legs slowing and dropping.

4 · Fingertip cartwheels · ×5

Only after the one-hand cartwheels are clean on both hands. Hurdle, then cartwheel with only the near hand, and only the fingertips touch, as if the floor were a hot stove. Kick the legs fast and straight, look forward (not at the hand), land in a lunge.

✓ **Right:** Almost no weight on the hand: the arm stays straight and there's no slap.

⚠ **Watch for:** A flat palm, a bending elbow or a slap means the hand is still holding her up and the legs aren't fast enough yet. Go back to the front-leg drive and one-hand cartwheels for a while. That's normal.

5 · Wedge cartwheels · two hands → one hand → a brush

A wedge ("cheese") mat on a non-slip floor, a mat at the bottom, clear space around it. The high end goes where she starts. Cartwheel DOWN the slope: the slope gives the legs extra time. Two hands until 5 in a row are clean, then one hand, then just a brush. A folded mat works too: start on top and cartwheel down.

✓ **Right:** Each stage clean 5 in a row before the next one. The no-hands feeling starts showing up here.

⚠ **Watch for:** Rushing the stages. If it gets messy, go back one stage. Check with the Acro teacher before doing the brush stage at home: it's the closest thing on the list to a real aerial.

Strong stuff + cartwheel skills

Pick two strong ones each session. The cartwheel skills are the base for everything.

6 · Strong stuff: pick two each session

20 jump lunges without stopping

Start in a lunge. Jump up, switch legs in the air, and land softly in a lunge with the other leg in front. Keep going.

✓ **Right:** Soft, quiet landings, the front knee over the ankle, chest tall.

⚠ **Watch for:** Loud, stiff landings, or the front knee falling inward.

10 single-leg squats per leg

Stand on one leg with the other foot just off the floor in front. Bend the standing knee slowly, sitting back as if onto a chair, then stand up tall. A hand on a counter for balance is fine.

✓ **Right:** The knee points over the toes, slow down and slow up, hips stay level.

⚠ **Watch for:** The knee falling inward, dropping down fast, or bouncing up.

30-second hollow hold

Lie on your back. Press the lower back into the floor, arms by the ears, legs straight and together. Lift the shoulders and legs a little off the floor, like a banana, and hold.

✓ **Right:** The lower back stays glued to the floor for the whole 30 seconds.

⚠ **Watch for:** The lower back lifting. If it does, bend the knees or lift the legs higher until it stays down.

Standing long jump past my own height

Both feet behind a line. Swing the arms back and bend, then swing them forward and jump as far as you can. Land on both feet and freeze.

✓ **Right:** Two-foot take-off and a soft landing with bent knees. Measure from the line to the back of the nearer heel and compare with her height.

⚠ **Watch for:** Stepping or falling backward on the landing: that jump doesn't count.

Single-leg hops

Hop on one leg on the spot, 10 on each leg.

✓ **Right:** Soft knee and a quiet landing every time.

⚠ **Watch for:** Landing on a straight, locked knee.

Superman hold (back extension)

Lie on the tummy. Long arms by the ears, long legs. Lift the arms, chest and legs a little off the floor and hold 15 seconds, 3 times.

✓ **Right:** Long and low, like flying. Neck long, eyes to the floor.

⚠ **Watch for:** Cranking the head back or lifting so high it pinches the lower back.

The cartwheel skills

Cartwheel: straight arms and legs, fast, lands facing the start

Lunge, then hand, hand, foot, foot along one straight line on the floor. The legs go straight over the top, wide like a star. Finish in a lunge facing where you started.

✓ **Right:** Arms and legs stay straight the whole way, it's quick, and hands and feet all land on the line.

⚠ **Watch for:** Bent knees or elbows, legs swinging round the side instead of over the top, or the head dropping before the hands go down.

Dive cartwheel (small hop before the hands) on the mat

From the hurdle, push off the front leg so both feet leave the floor for a moment before the hands land. Then it's a normal cartwheel: hand, hand, foot, foot. Start with a tiny hop; it grows with practice. On the mat.

✓ **Right:** A small moment in the air, straight arms reaching long, a soft landing in a lunge.

⚠ **Watch for:** Diving head-first at the floor, bent arms catching the weight, or going big before a small one is clean.

Round-off landing feet together, chest up

Hurdle and lunge like a cartwheel, but as the legs pass over the top, snap them together and turn so both feet land at the same moment, facing back the way you came.

✓ **Right:** Both feet land together, chest up, arms up by the ears.

⚠ **Watch for:** Feet landing one after the other, or the chest still down at the floor on the landing.

The plan · Oct 12 – Nov 8

Monday = Acro. Thursday + Friday = about 10 minutes on the mat. Tick only what was clean.

Week 1 Oct 12–18

Phase 1 · Show the teacher

Home list: Hurdle ×10 · Drive ×10 · One-hand far ×5 + near ×5 · Strong: pick two

☐ **Mon Oct 12 · Acro:** Tell the Acro teacher about the plan. Ask when she can watch the drills.

Teacher's note:

	Warm-up	Hurdle	Drive	1-hand	Fingertip	Wedge	Strong ×2	Chest up	Best thing today
Thu Oct 15	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	*later*	☐☐	☐	
Fri Oct 16	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	*later*	☐☐	☐	

Week 2 Oct 19–25

Phase 1 · Show the teacher

Home list: Hurdle ×10 · Drive ×10 · One-hand far ×5 + near ×5 · Strong: pick two

☐ **Mon Oct 19 · Acro:** Show the teacher the drill videos from Thursday and Friday. Ask questions 1–3 on page 8 and write the answers there.

Teacher's note:

	Warm-up	Hurdle	Drive	1-hand	Fingertip	Wedge	Strong ×2	Chest up	Best thing today
Thu Oct 22	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	*later*	☐☐	☐	
Fri Oct 23	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	*later*	☐☐	☐	

☐ **Gate · end of Phase 1:** Acro teacher has seen the drills and set the order. If her order is different, follow hers.

Not yet? Keep doing this list next week.

Week 3 Oct 26 – Nov 1

Phase 2 · Build the engine

Home list: Hurdle ×10 · Drive ×10 · One-hand far ×5 + near ×5 · Strong: pick two · Fridays: try 10 in a row on each hand

☐ **Mon Oct 26 · Acro:** Any changes to the order or the drills? Write them in the note.

Teacher's note:

	Warm-up	Hurdle	Drive	1-hand	Fingertip	Wedge	Strong ×2	Chest up	Best thing today
Thu Oct 29	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	*later*	☐☐	☐	
Fri Oct 30	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	*later*	☐☐	☐	

Week 4 Nov 2–8

Phase 2 · Build the engine

Home list: Hurdle ×10 · Drive ×10 · One-hand far ×5 + near ×5 · Strong: pick two · Fridays: try 10 in a row on each hand

☐ **Mon Nov 2 · Acro:** Ask the teacher to watch a one-hand cartwheel on each hand.

Teacher's note:

	Warm-up	Hurdle	Drive	1-hand	Fingertip	Wedge	Strong ×2	Chest up	Best thing today
Thu Nov 5	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	*later*	☐☐	☐	
Fri Nov 6	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	*later*	☐☐	☐	

The plan · Nov 9 – Dec 6

Shaded boxes come later: start them only after the gate before them.

Week 5 Nov 9–15

Phase 2 · Build the engine

Home list: Hurdle ×10 · Drive ×10 · One-hand far ×5 + near ×5 · Strong: pick two · Fridays: try 10 in a row on each hand

☐ **Mon Nov 9 · Acro:** Show the teacher Sofia's one-hand cartwheels, both hands. Ready for fingertips?

Teacher's note:

	Warm-up	Hurdle	Drive	1-hand	Fingertip	Wedge	Strong ×2	Chest up	Best thing today
Thu Nov 12	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	*later*	☐☐	☐	
Fri Nov 13	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	*later*	☐☐	☐	

☐ **Gate · end of Phase 2:** One-hand cartwheels: 10 clean in a row on the far hand AND on the near hand (test it on a Friday).

Not yet? Keep doing this list next week.

Week 6 Nov 16–22

Phase 3 · Lighter hand

Home list: Hurdle ×10 · Drive ×10 · One-hand near ×5 · Fingertip ×5 · Strong: pick two

☐ **Mon Nov 16 · Acro:** Ask the teacher to watch a fingertip cartwheel. Is the hand light enough?

Teacher's note:

	Warm-up	Hurdle	Drive	1-hand	Fingertip	Wedge	Strong ×2	Chest up	Best thing today
Thu Nov 19	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	☐☐	☐	
Fri Nov 20	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	☐☐	☐	

Week 7 Nov 23–29

Phase 3 · Lighter hand

Home list: Hurdle ×10 · Drive ×10 · One-hand near ×5 · Fingertip ×5 · Strong: pick two

☐ **Mon Nov 23 · Acro:** Ask the teacher what she wants to see before the wedge.

Teacher's note:

	Warm-up	Hurdle	Drive	1-hand	Fingertip	Wedge	Strong ×2	Chest up	Best thing today
Thu Nov 26 Thanksgiving: rest, or move it to Wed or Sat. Keep this week light.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	☐☐	☐	
Fri Nov 27	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	☐☐	☐	

Week 8 Nov 30 – Dec 6

Phase 3 · Lighter hand

Home list: Hurdle ×10 · Drive ×10 · One-hand near ×5 · Fingertip ×5 · Strong: pick two

☐ **Mon Nov 30 · Acro:** Ask question 4 on page 8: OK to start the wedge at home? OK for the brush stage at home?

Teacher's note:

	Warm-up	Hurdle	Drive	1-hand	Fingertip	Wedge	Strong ×2	Chest up	Best thing today
Thu Dec 3	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	☐☐	☐	
Fri Dec 4	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	*later*	☐☐	☐	

☐ **Gate · end of Phase 3:** Fingertip cartwheels ×5 with a straight arm and no slap. The teacher said OK to start the wedge.

Not yet? Keep doing this list next week.

The plan · Dec 7 – Dec 31

Dec 7–20: Thursday + Friday as usual. From Dec 21: one session a week keeps it warm. Film everything for January.

Week 9 Dec 7–13

Phase 4 · Down the wedge

Home list: Drive ×10 · Fingertip ×5 · Wedge: two hands until 5 clean in a row, then one hand ×5 · Strong: pick two

☐ **Mon Dec 7 · Acro:** If the teacher said OK, the wedge starts this week. Ask her to watch one more fingertip cartwheel.

Teacher's note:

	Warm-up	Hurdle	Drive	1-hand	Fingertip	Wedge	Strong ×2	Chest up	Best thing today
Thu Dec 10	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐☐	☐	
Fri Dec 11	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐☐	☐	

Week 10 Dec 14–20

Phase 4 · Down the wedge

Home list: Drive ×10 · Fingertip ×5 · Wedge: two hands until 5 clean in a row, then one hand ×5 · Strong: pick two

☐ **Mon Dec 14 · Acro:** Show the teacher a wedge video (two hands).

Teacher's note:

	Warm-up	Hurdle	Drive	1-hand	Fingertip	Wedge	Strong ×2	Chest up	Best thing today
Thu Dec 17	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐☐	☐	
Fri Dec 18	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐☐	☐	

☐ **Gate · end of Phase 4:** Wedge, one hand: 5 clean in a row. The brush stage only after the teacher says OK.

Not yet? Keep doing this list next week.

Week 11 Dec 21–27

Holidays · Keep it warm

Home list: One session a week, any day: Hurdle ×10 · Drive ×10 · the newest drill unlocked ×5 (the brush only if the teacher OK'd it) · film every drill

☐ **Mon Dec 21 · Acro:** If there's class: show the teacher the newest wedge video.

Teacher's note:

	Warm-up	Hurdle	Drive	1-hand	Fingertip	Wedge	Strong ×2	Chest up	Best thing today
Session date _____	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐☐	☐	

Week 12 Dec 28–31

Holidays · Keep it warm

Home list: One session a week, any day: Hurdle ×10 · Drive ×10 · the newest drill unlocked ×5 (the brush only if the teacher OK'd it) · film every drill

☐ **Mon Dec 28 · Acro:** If there's class: show the teacher the newest video. Ask what she wants to see in January.

Teacher's note:

	Warm-up	Hurdle	Drive	1-hand	Fingertip	Wedge	Strong ×2	Chest up	Best thing today
Session date _____	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐☐	☐	

Teacher, wins and the finish line

Her answers beat this sheet.

Questions for my Acro teacher

1. Which of these drills should I do at home, and which only in class?

2. What order do you teach the aerial in?

3. What am I ready for right now?

4. Is it OK to do the wedge at home? The brush stage?

Finish line · December 31

- [ ] Hurdle and front-leg drive: clean, chest up, every time
- [ ] One-hand cartwheels: 10 clean in a row, both hands
- [ ] Fingertip cartwheels: straight arm, no slap
- [ ] Wedge: as far as the teacher says
- [ ] Filmed every drill in the last week of December
- [ ] Showed the videos to the Acro teacher in January

Not every box will be ticked by December 31, and that's normal. In January, the taper week (Jan 3–8), the Winter Formal (Jan 8–10) and the comp weekends mean no new drills or stages: keep the ones Sofia already has. After that, pick up from wherever she is.

Wins and wobbles

What got better? What was hard? One line each time.